IB English A: Language and Literature · Paper 2

A Doll's House

Henrik Ibsen · A Paper 2 guide

Comparative essay preparation
Event bank · Quote bank · Issue arcs by act and across the play
Dig deeper · Self-test

Contents

1. How to use this guide 3
2. The examination 4
3. Context 5
4. At a glance 6
5. Event bank 7
6. Characters 9
7. Issues 11
8. Issue and act grid 14
9. Ibsen's methods 15
10. Dig deeper 16
11. Quote bank 18
12. Self-test 21
13. Sources 22

How to use this guide

References take the form III.286: Act III, line 286, where each line of dialogue counts as one line, however long. A stage direction is referenced to the line it follows, for example III.381 s.d.. Lines are counted from the start of each act in R. Farquharson Sharp's translation. Act I has 485 lines, Act II 426 and Act III 381.

> **Built for Paper 2.** The issue arcs trace each concern through the three acts, and Dig deeper sets out the critical readings to test against the play.

The examination

Course and paper	IB Diploma English A: Language and Literature, Paper 2: the comparative essay on two literary works studied in the course. Paper 2 is not a set-text exam: the questions are general, they do not name any work, and there are no extracts.
Format	1 hour 45 minutes at both SL and HL. Answer one of four general questions, comparing two of the literary works you have studied. 25 marks.
Criteria	A Knowledge, understanding and interpretation (5). B Analysis and evaluation (10), in two strands: B1 how meaning is shaped by language, technique, style and broader authorial choices (5); B2 the similarities and differences between the two works (5). C Focus and organisation (5). D Language (5).
What this means for revision	You will not know the question in advance, so you cannot prepare a single essay. You prepare a small number of moments from each work that you know in detail, grouped by issue, and you rehearse how each work handles those issues differently. That is what the issue arcs, the event bank and the quote bank in this guide are for. Comparison must be structural: every paragraph needs both works, and criterion B2 assesses it directly.

iSWIM for Paper 2. Use the five guiding questions on every prompt.

i	What is the issue of significance? The concern beneath the prompt's topic word.
S	Why does it matter? The human, social or philosophical stakes.
W	What does each author want you to understand about it?
I	How does each author get you to understand it? Structure, form, characterisation, voice, staging.
M	What does each work position its audience towards, and what does the comparison reveal? The essay-level M comes from the tension between M(A) and M(B).

Write each paragraph with PEACE ACT: Point, Evidence, Analysis, Comparison, Extension, Audience, Context, Tie-back. Characters do not exist: reach through the characters to the choices the writer makes with them.

iSWIM tells you how to plan. Thinking with iSWIM tells you how to think. Your text-type guide tells you what to notice and what to call it.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

Composition and first performance

Ibsen wrote the play in 1879 while living in Italy and Germany; it was first performed at the Royal Theatre in Copenhagen in December 1879.

Source: LitCharts; Barron's Book Notes

Laura Kieler

The plot draws on the case of Ibsen's friend Laura Kieler, who borrowed money in secret to pay for her husband's recovery and was later committed to an asylum when the debt was discovered.

Source: LitCharts

The alternative ending

For an early German production, Ibsen wrote an alternative ending in which Nora, seeing her children, cannot leave. He called it a barbaric outrage on the play and wrote it only to prevent someone else from rewriting the ending.

Source: LitCharts; Ibsen's letters

Ibsen and the women's movement

In 1898, at a banquet of the Norwegian Women's Rights League, Ibsen said he had not consciously worked for the women's cause and that his task had been the description of humanity.

Source: Ibsen, speech of 1898

At a glance

Act	Setting	Events	Event titles
Act I	The Helmers' sitting room, Christmas Eve	E1–E4	Christmas shopping and macaroons; Nora's secret; Krogstad's threat; Helmer on lies and mothers
Act II	The same room, Christmas Day	E5–E8	The costume and the tarantella; Doctor Rank; The letter in the box; The wonderful thing
Act III	The same room, the night after Christmas	E9–E14	Mrs Linde and Krogstad; Helmer reads the letter; The second letter and the "forgiveness"; The first serious conversation; Duties to herself; The door

Event bank

14 numbered events in order. Read one act for close revision, or E1 to E14 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Act I

E1 Christmas shopping and macaroons I.1–10

Nora comes home with parcels and a Christmas tree, tips the porter generously and secretly eats macaroons I.3. Helmer calls her his lark and squirrel I.4 and teases her about spending I.10.

Why it matters. The opening shows the marriage as a performance of pet names and small deceptions, with money at the centre.

Dig deeper. Why does the play open with a lie about macaroons? What does the smallness of the lie prepare us for?

E2 Nora's secret I.85–173

Nora's old friend Christine Linde arrives, widowed and poor I.85 s.d.. Nora reveals that the year in Italy that saved Helmer's life I.125 was paid for with money she raised herself I.173, and that she has been repaying it secretly, partly by copying I.207.

Why it matters. The doll of the first scene is revealed as the one who acted, in secret, to save her husband.

Dig deeper. Nora is proud of the loan. Why does Ibsen let the audience see her pride before it sees the danger?

E3 Krogstad's threat I.218–399

Krogstad, a clerk at Helmer's bank, is about to be dismissed. He tells Nora that the bond she signed bears her father's signature dated three days after his death I.399: she forged it.

Why it matters. The secret becomes a crime, and the plot's machinery starts to turn.

E4 Helmer on lies and mothers I.464–476

Helmer explains why Krogstad is morally lost I.464: lying poisons a home I.474, and almost everyone who goes to the bad has had a deceitful mother I.476.

Why it matters. Helmer condemns his wife without knowing it; the act ends with Nora afraid of corrupting her children.

Act II

E5 The costume and the tarantella II.30–139

Nora is to dance the tarantella at the fancy-dress ball II.30, and pleads with Helmer to keep Krogstad on. Helmer refuses, partly because Krogstad is too familiar with him II.119, and sends the dismissal letter.

Why it matters. Nora's influence over Helmer is shown to be limited to play.

E6 Doctor Rank II.38–214

Rank, dying of an inherited disease II.38, flirts with Nora over silk stockings II.188 and declares that he loves her II.214. She refuses to ask him for the money.

Why it matters. Nora could buy her way out through a man's love and chooses not to.

Dig deeper. Why does Nora stop herself from asking Rank for help once he declares his love?

E7 The letter in the box II.307–323

Krogstad reveals his ambition II.307 and drops a letter revealing everything into Helmer's locked letter-box II.323.

Why it matters. A single prop now holds the plot: everyone on stage can see the letter, and only Helmer has the key.

E8 The wonderful thing II.329–341

Nora confesses the forgery to Mrs Linde II.329 and says she expects "a wonderful thing" II.341: that Helmer will take the guilt on himself. She dances the tarantella wildly to delay him.

Why it matters. Nora's hope sets the test Helmer will fail in Act III.

Act III

E9 Mrs Linde and Krogstad III.9–77

Mrs Linde, who once left Krogstad to marry for money, offers to marry him now III.9. She tells him not to recall his letter III.75: Helmer must know everything III.77.

Why it matters. A second couple chooses honesty and partnership, as a counterweight to the Helmers.

Dig deeper. Why does Mrs Linde, who could stop the letter, decide that Helmer must read it?

E10 Helmer reads the letter III.236–238

Helmer reads Krogstad's letter and turns on Nora: she is a hypocrite, a liar and a criminal III.236, and has destroyed his happiness III.238.

Why it matters. The wonderful thing does not happen: Helmer thinks only of himself.

E11 The second letter and the "forgiveness" III.251–253

A second letter returns the bond. Helmer is saved, and at once forgives Nora III.253.

Why it matters. His forgiveness depends on his safety, which Nora now sees clearly.

E12 The first serious conversation III.262–286

Nora sits Helmer down III.262 and points out that in eight years they have never had a serious conversation III.270. She has been his doll-wife as she was her father's doll-child III.286.

Why it matters. The play changes form: from intrigue to discussion.

E13 Duties to herself III.314–316

Against Helmer's "most sacred duties" III.309, Nora sets duties to herself III.314 and the claim to be a reasonable human being first III.316.

Why it matters. The play's central claim, made in the plainest language.

E14 The door III.376–381

Nora leaves her keys and her ring III.366, says the most wonderful thing would be a real marriage III.380, and goes. Helmer is left with a flash of hope as a door shuts below III.381 s.d..

Why it matters. The ending is a sound, not a resolution: the audience does not see what Nora becomes.

Dig deeper. Ibsen wrote an alternative ending for a German production in which Nora stays for the children. Why might he have called it a barbaric outrage, and what would the play lose?

Characters

Nora Helmer

Helmer's wife, mother of three.

- Plays the pet I.4 while hiding the loan I.173.
- Forged her father's signature II.329.
- Leaves to educate herself III.298.

Arc. From doll to a woman who walks out to find out who she is.

Torvald Helmer

A lawyer, newly made manager of the bank.

- Patronising and affectionate I.10.
- Moralises about lies I.476.
- Fails the test III.345.

Arc. Ends alone, still hoping for a wonderful thing III.381.

Kristine (Christine) Linde

Nora's old friend, a widow seeking work.

- Learns Nora's secret I.173.
- Reunites with Krogstad III.9 and insists the truth come out.

Arc. Chooses an honest partnership; a counterweight to Nora.

Nils Krogstad

A bank clerk with a past forgery.

- Threatens Nora I.399.
- Aims at power II.307.
- Returns the bond after Mrs Linde's offer.

Arc. The play's villain turns out to be capable of change.

Doctor Rank

The Helmers' friend, dying of an inherited disease.

- Inherited illness II.38.
- Declares his love II.214.

Arc. Leaves his card marked with a black cross III.208 and goes to die.

Issues

Each issue is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Gender, marriage and the doll

The marriage is built on roles: the man who protects and the woman who pleases. The play exposes the arrangement and lets the wife walk out of it.

Act I	Helmer treats Nora as a pet I.4 while she has secretly saved his life I.173. Quotations: Q1, Q2, Q3, Q4, Q7
Act II	Nora's power over him is play II.30; she hopes he will sacrifice himself for her II.341. Quotations: Q8, Q10, Q11, Q14
Act III	He fails the test III.345; she names the marriage III.286 and leaves III.380. Quotations: Q15, Q16, Q17, Q18, Q19, Q20, Q21, Q22, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q28, Q29, Q30, Q31

The whole arc. From lark and squirrel to "a reasonable human being": Nora renames herself.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Is A Doll's House a play about women, or about any person denied a self? Ibsen himself denied he was writing for the women's movement (see Dig deeper).
> - Does Helmer love Nora? Test his claims against what he does when the letter arrives.

Money, debt and power

Money governs everything: Helmer's new post at the bank, Nora's loan, Krogstad's job, Mrs Linde's marriage. The secret debt is the plot.

Act I	Spending and earning: Helmer warns against debt; Nora has borrowed and works in secret I.207. Quotations: Q2, Q3, Q4, Q5
Act II	Krogstad turns debt into leverage II.307. Quotations: Q12, Q13
Act III	Nora describes marriage as a transfer of ownership III.282 and returns the keys III.366. Quotations: Q20

The whole arc. The play ends when Nora refuses to take anything from Helmer, either now or later.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Who has economic power in the play, and how is it disguised?

Law, forgery and the individual conscience

Nora broke the law to save a life. The play sets the law and its "morality" against motive and conscience.

Act I	The forgery is exposed I.399. Quotations: Q5
Act II	Nora admits it II.329. Quotations: Q13
Act III	Nora decides to test society's rules for herself III.324. Quotations: Q27

The whole arc. Ibsen's notes for the play describe two kinds of conscience, one in man and one in woman; the plot puts them in conflict.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Was Nora wrong to forge the signature? On what grounds?

Deception, performance and the mask

Everyone in the house performs. The play is full of disguises, from the macaroons to the fancy-dress costume.

Act I	The first lie is about macaroons I.3; Helmer preaches against masks I.474. Quotations: Q1, Q6
Act II	The tarantella becomes a performance to hide panic II.30. Quotations: Q8, Q14
Act III	Nora changes out of her costume into everyday dress III.258 before the conversation III.262. Quotations: Q17

The whole arc. The play ends when performance stops and talk begins.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Who in the play is not performing a role?

Self, duty and freedom

The play's ending sets duties to oneself against duties to husband, children and society.

Act I	Nora is defined by her family roles I.4. Quotations: –
Act II	Krogstad guesses that she has thought of drowning herself II.313; Nora begins to see herself as alone. Quotations: –

Act III	She claims duties to herself III.314 and the right to understand herself alone III.298. Quotations: Q21, Q23, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q27, Q30, Q31, Q32

The whole arc. Selfhood is something Nora must leave home to find.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Is Nora's departure an act of freedom or of abandonment? Can it be both?
> - Is the play's argument individualist, or does it depend on Nora being a woman?

Morality, heredity and disease

Helmer's morality is about appearances; Rank's disease and Krogstad's past show the play's interest in inheritance and corruption.

Act I	Helmer blames corruption on deceitful mothers I.476. Quotations: Q6, Q7
Act II	Rank is dying of his father's sins II.38. Quotations: Q9
Act III	Helmer judges Nora as he judged Krogstad III.236. Quotations: Q15, Q28

The whole arc. The play asks whether moral failure is inherited or chosen.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - How does Rank's illness connect to Helmer's fear for his children?

Issue and act grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that issue's arc.

Issue	Act I	Act II	Act III
Gender, marriage and the doll	Q1, Q2, Q3, Q4, Q7	Q8, Q10, Q11, Q14	Q15, Q16, Q17, Q18, Q19, Q20, Q21, Q22, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q28, Q29, Q30, Q31
Money, debt and power	Q2, Q3, Q4, Q5	Q12, Q13	Q20
Law, forgery and the individual conscience	Q5	Q13	Q27
Deception, performance and the mask	Q1, Q6	Q8, Q14	Q17
Self, duty and freedom			Q21, Q23, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q27, Q30, Q31, Q32
Morality, heredity and disease	Q6, Q7	Q9	Q15, Q28

Ibsen’s methods

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

The well-made play, then the discussion

Acts I and II use the machinery of the well-made play: a secret, a threatening letter, a deadline. In Act III Nora sits down III.262 and the play becomes a discussion, which Shaw saw as Ibsen’s technical innovation.

Symbolic props

The macaroons I.3, the Christmas tree, the letter-box II.323, the costume and the door III.381 s.d..

Dramatic irony

Helmer’s speech on deceitful mothers I.476 is delivered to the woman who has done what he describes.

Parallel couples

Mrs Linde and Krogstad choose honesty III.9 while the Helmers’ marriage collapses.

Naturalistic dialogue

Ordinary language carries the climax: “Duties to myself.” III.314.

Dig deeper

The surface overview is in the event bank and issue arcs. These sections go further, into Ibsen's own statements, the play's form, its economics, its use of performance, and the debate over its ending. Every claim about the play is referenced; critical readings are offered for evaluation.

Ibsen's own words

On the surface. The play is a feminist manifesto.

In his notes for the play (1878) Ibsen wrote that there are two kinds of spiritual law and two kinds of conscience, one in man and another in woman, and that a woman cannot be herself in a society made by men. The plot puts those two consciences in conflict: Nora broke the law to save a life I.173; Helmer judges by appearances III.236.

Twenty years later he told the Norwegian Women's Rights League that he had not consciously worked for women's rights; his task had been the description of humanity. It could be argued that Nora's claim to be "a reasonable human being" III.316 supports that reading: she claims humanity before womanhood.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Can a play be feminist if its author denied writing for feminism?
> - Does it matter what Ibsen intended?

From well-made play to discussion

On the surface. A melodrama of secrets and letters.

Shaw argued in The Quintessence of Ibsenism that Ibsen's innovation was the discussion: at the climax, instead of a revelation followed by reconciliation, the characters sit down and argue. Nora draws attention to it herself III.270.

The well-made plot (secret, letter, deadline) is used and then abandoned, as if the play outgrows its own form.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why might a debate be more dramatic than a revelation?

Money and the marriage market

On the surface. A domestic drama.

Almost every relationship in the play is financial: Helmer's promotion, Nora's loan, Krogstad's job, Mrs Linde's first marriage for money. A Marxist or economic reading could argue that Nora's description of her marriage III.282 describes property, not love.

Questions to explore

- Is Nora freed by refusing Helmer's money, or made poor?

Performance and the self

On the surface. Nora pretends.

It could be argued, following critics such as Toril Moi, that the play is about theatricality: Nora performs the role Helmer wants, dances the tarantella as a performance of panic II.30, and only stops performing when she changes out of her costume and sits down to talk.

Questions to explore

- Is the Nora of Act III more real, or another role?

The ending and its critics

On the surface. Nora leaves.

The door was shocking in 1879; Ibsen had to write an alternative ending for one German production. Critics have debated whether Nora's departure is believable, whether she abandons her children, and whether Helmer's last flash of hope III.381 leaves any possibility of change.

Questions to explore

- What happens to Nora next? Why does Ibsen refuse to tell us?
- Would the play be stronger or weaker if Nora stayed?

Quote bank

32 quotations in order of appearance.

Act I

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	I.4	HELMER: "Is that my little lark twittering out there?" The first line of the marriage: Nora as a pet bird. Gender · Deception
Q2	I.10	HELMER: "Has my little spendthrift been wasting money again?" Affection and money in one phrase. Money · Gender
Q3	I.173	NORA: "It was I who saved Torvald's life." Nora's pride in her secret act. Gender · Money
Q4	I.207	NORA: "I was lucky enough to get a lot of copying to do" Secret paid work: Nora has earned money in a world that assumes she cannot. Money · Gender
Q5	I.399	KROGSTAD: "your father signed this bond three days after his death" The forgery exposed by a date. Money · Law
Q6	I.474	HELMER: "infects and poisons the whole life of a home" Helmer's language of moral contagion, aimed at Krogstad and landing on Nora. Morality · Deception
Q7	I.476	HELMER: "has had a deceitful mother" Moral corruption traced to mothers, with Nora in the room. Morality · Gender

Act II

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q8	II.30	NORA: "dance the Tarantella that I learned at Capri" The dance that will become Nora's performance of panic. Deception · Gender
Q9	II.38	NORA: "consumption of the spine" Rank's inherited illness: the father's sins visited on the son. Morality

Q10	**II.188**	**RANK:** “Silk stockings.” A flirtation conducted through clothing. Gender
Q11	**II.214**	**RANK:** “The only one who would gladly give his life for your sake.” Rank’s declaration, which ends the possibility of asking him for money. Gender
Q12	**II.307**	**KROGSTAD:** “It will be Nils Krogstad and not Torvald Helmer who manages the bank.” Krogstad’s ambition turns the threat into a bid for power. Money
Q13	**II.329**	**NORA:** “I forged a name.” The confession to Mrs Linde, four words long. Law Money
Q14	**II.341**	**NORA:** “A wonderful thing is going to happen!” The hope the last act will test. Gender Deception

Act III

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q15	**III.236**	**HELMER:** “a hypocrite, a liar—worse, worse—a criminal” Helmer’s judgement of his wife, in the language he used for Krogstad. Gender Morality
Q16	**III.238**	**HELMER:** “Now you have destroyed all my happiness.” Self-pity first. Gender
Q17	**III.253**	**HELMER:** “I have forgiven you, Nora; I swear to you I have forgiven you.” Forgiveness offered once he is safe. Gender Deception
Q18	**III.270**	**NORA:** “this is the first time we two, you and I, husband and wife, have had a serious conversation?” The discussion that changes the play’s form. Gender
Q19	**III.278**	**NORA:** “You have never loved me. You have only thought it pleasant to be in love with me.” Love redefined as pleasure. Gender
Q20	**III.282**	**NORA:** “I was simply transferred from papa’s hands into yours” Marriage as a change of owner. Gender Money

Q21	III.286	**NORA:** "I have been your doll-wife, just as at home I was papa's doll-child" The title explained in Nora's own words. Gender Self
Q22	III.286	**NORA:** "our home has been nothing but a playroom" The house as a stage set. Gender
Q23	III.298	**NORA:** "I must stand quite alone, if I am to understand myself" Self-knowledge requires leaving. Self
Q24	III.314	**NORA:** "Duties to myself." Three words against Helmer's sacred duties. Self Gender
Q25	III.315	**HELMER:** "Before all else, you are a wife and a mother." Helmer's definition of a woman. Gender Self
Q26	III.316	**NORA:** "before all else I am a reasonable human being" Nora's reply, matching his phrase. Self Gender
Q27	III.324	**NORA:** "I am going to see if I can make out who is right, the world or I." Society's law against individual judgement. Self Law
Q28	III.345	**HELMER:** "But no man would sacrifice his honour for the one he loves." The sentence that decides the marriage. Gender Morality
Q29	III.346	**NORA:** "It is a thing hundreds of thousands of women have done." Nora answers for her sex, not only herself. Gender
Q30	III.352	**NORA:** "Perhaps—if your doll is taken away from you." The doll image turned against Helmer. Gender Self
Q31	III.380	**NORA:** "That our life together would be a real wedlock." Her last definition of marriage. Gender Self
Q32	III.381 s.d.	"The sound of a door shutting is heard from below." The most famous stage direction in modern drama. Self

Self-test

7 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **What does Nora eat in secret?**
   Almonds / Cakes / Chocolates / Macaroons
2. **Why did Nora borrow the money?**
   To buy the house / To help Mrs Linde / To pay for a year in Italy that saved Helmer's life / To pay her father's debts
3. **How is the forgery exposed?**
   Helmer recognised the writing / Krogstad saw her sign it / The bank found it / The bond is dated three days after her father's death
4. **What dance does Nora perform?**
   A mazurka / A polka / A waltz / The tarantella
5. **What is Rank dying of?**
   A broken heart / An inherited disease of the spine / Drink / Fever
6. **What does Nora say she has been to Helmer?**
   His child / His doll-wife / His partner / His servant
7. **What is the last sound of the play?**
   A bell / A child crying / A door shutting / A gunshot

Answers

1. Macaroons I.3
2. To pay for a year in Italy that saved Helmer's life I.125
3. The bond is dated three days after her father's death I.399
4. The tarantella II.30
5. An inherited disease of the spine II.38
6. His doll-wife III.286
7. A door shutting III.381 s.d.

Sources

- Henrik Ibsen, *A Doll's House* (1879), translated by R. Farquharson Sharp.
- LitCharts and Barron's Book Notes on *A Doll's House*.
- Henrik Ibsen, "Notes for the Tragedy of Our Time" (1878) and speech to the Norwegian Women's Rights League (1898).
- George Bernard Shaw, *The Quintessence of Ibsenism* (1891).